

CORE FORMULA

Cue -> feeling -> likely need -> tentative phrase -> pause -> follow or release. -> Basic: "It sounds like you are [feeling] because you needed [need]." -> **Softer:** "I might be reading this wrong, but part of the [feeling] is needing [need]." -> **Professional:** "The concern isn't the change itself, but needing clearer notice before decisions move." -> **Digital:** "Sounds frustrating - especially if what you needed was clearer timing upfront." -> **Minimum:** "It sounds frustrating because you needed clearer next steps."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one feeling plus one likely need in a single tentative sentence, then pause and let them accept, adjust, or decline - e.g. "It sounds frustrating because you needed clearer next steps."

BEST FOR

- Someone sounds upset, disappointed, tense, relieved, or excited and the need beneath it is reasonably visible
- Facts alone are not explaining the emotional weight of the moment
- A complaint keeps repeating and the underlying need wants recognising before problem-solving
- Slowing a conflict without agreeing to inaccurate facts
- A professional conversation needs warmth without becoming sentimental
- Terse digital messages where a concise reflection reduces misread intent

PHRASE BANK

Quick · Short one-liners

- "It sounds frustrating because you needed clearer next steps."
- "Sounds frustrating - especially if what you needed was clearer timing upfront."
- "That sounds frustrating, especially if you needed more notice."
- "Makes sense that this would feel tense if reliability was the need."
- "Sounds like acknowledgement would help before solutions."
- "That sounds disappointing - you wanted it to matter to them."
- "I hear a need for a cleaner handoff. Is that close?"
- "Sounds like the need is more notice, not less work."

Social / personal · Warmth and rapport

- "It sounds like you're disappointed because you wanted to feel included earlier."
- "Maybe part of the frustration is needing your effort to be noticed."
- "That sounds upsetting because you needed more honesty in the moment."
- "It sounds like the hard part is needing reliability and not getting it."
- "I may be off, but it sounds like you needed someone to check in rather than assume you were fine."
- "That sounds disappointing because you wanted them to remember it mattered."
- "Sounds like you needed to feel like a priority, not an afterthought."

Workplace / decision · Work and meetings

- "It sounds like the frustration is about needing clearer ownership before the deadline."
- "The concern seems to be needing more notice, not resisting the change itself."
- "It sounds like you needed a cleaner decision path before work started."
- "Part of this seems to be needing confidence that your input will actually be used."
- "It sounds like the pressure came from needing priorities to be explicit."

- "It sounds like the need is earlier priority clarity, not less responsibility."
- "The concern isn't the change itself, but needing clearer notice before decisions move."

Naming the need · Clear, direct reflections

- "It sounds like what mattered was needing respect for that boundary."
- "It sounds like you needed the decision made before, not explained after."
- "It sounds like the real need is being told early, not last."
- "Sounds like the ask is simple - knowing what matters first."
- "It sounds like you needed a say in how it happened, not just the outcome."
- "I hear a need for a clear owner and a firm timeline."
- "It sounds like you needed one clear next step before more options."

Conflict / repair · De-escalation and repair

- "It sounds like you felt hurt because you needed your side to be taken seriously."
- "Maybe the anger is partly about needing a fairer process."
- "It sounds like the issue was needing a real apology, not just an explanation."
- "I hear that you needed me to check before deciding."
- "You're right - it sounds like you needed acknowledgement before explanation."
- "I can see why that landed badly; it sounds like you needed to be heard first."
- "Sounds like what stung was being added after the fact, not the change itself."

High-pressure · Pressure and urgency

- "It sounds like the immediate need is safety and clarity."
- "It sounds like this needs action first, then we can unpack the rest."
- "It sounds like you need one clear next step before anything else."
- "I hear it - the priority right now is a decision, not a discussion."
- "Sounds like what you need first is to know it's handled."
- "I'll keep this practical: you need a clear owner and a timeline."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: You're angry because you need attention.
Better: You sound angry because this mattered.
Best: It sounds frustrating because you needed your concern to be taken seriously.
- Weak: You're clearly insecure about the change.
Better: The change feels unsettling.
Best: It sounds unsettling because you needed more clarity before things moved.
- Weak: You just want control.
Better: You wanted more say in it.
Best: It sounds like you felt tense because you needed some choice in how it happened.
- Weak: You're upset because nobody validated you.
Better: You wanted acknowledgement.
Best: It sounds hurtful because you needed the effort recognised before the next ask.

DECISION TREE

If No visible feeling cue

Use plain reflective listening or a summary check instead of guessing a feeling.

"So the main point is the timeline slipped - have I got that right?"

If Feeling is clear but the need isn't

Name only the feeling (emotional labelling); don't reach for a need you can't see.

"That sounds really frustrating."

If Feeling and need both visible, context is safe

Offer one tentative feeling-plus-need sentence, then pause.

"It sounds frustrating because you needed more notice."

If Context is tense or too formal for the depth

Keep it practical or validate the concern rather than naming the need.

"That's a fair thing to be annoyed about."

If They accept, add, or correct

Follow an accept or add; take a correction gracefully and adjust your reading.

"Fair - so it was less about the notice and more about being asked."

If They withdraw, or the moment now needs action

Release the move or switch to a clear next step or clear request.

"Let's make the owner and timing clear first."

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation

One short sentence in a normal tone; don't sound like a counsellor. — "That sounds disappointing because you wanted them to remember it mattered."

Workplace conversation

Keep the need concrete - clarity, ownership, timing, priority - and skip psychological labels. — "It sounds frustrating because you needed clearer ownership before the deadline."

Conflict or repair

Validate first if they feel dismissed, then name the need; don't use it in place of an apology. — "I can see why that landed badly. It sounds like you needed acknowledgement before explanation."

Digital message

One sentence, no stacked prompts; add a release line so it can't misread as a verdict. — "Sounds frustrating, especially if what you needed was more notice before the decision. I may be reading that wrong."

High-pressure moment

Prioritise safety, action, and clarity; don't force emotional processing. — "It sounds like you need one clear next step before anything else."

Coaching or mentoring

Use it to clarify motivation, not to diagnose; ask before moving into advice. — "It sounds like the hesitation is partly needing more confidence before committing."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person only wants direct information or a fast decision
- You have too little evidence to infer a need
- The wording would sound clinical, patronising, or too intimate for the relationship
- The person has asked you not to analyse them
- The moment needs action, safety, boundaries, or accountability first
- You are tempted to use the reflection to steer them toward your preferred outcome

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

Collect ten everyday complaint lines from your week, your texts, or things you overhear. For each, underline the single word or phrase carrying the feeling.

Day 2 — Name the need

For each of the ten lines, write one concrete need underneath - notice, clarity, respect, inclusion, reliability. Only pick needs the actual words support.

Day 3 — Write the sentence

Turn five of them into one tentative sentence each: "It sounds like [feeling] because you needed [need]." Then cut each sentence by about a third.

Day 4 — Evidence check

For those five, mark your evidence for the feeling and for the need. Where the need is really a guess, downgrade to naming the feeling only (TC006 emotional labelling).

Day 5 — Practise recovery

Say one reflection deliberately too strongly, then repair it out loud with "I may be reading that wrong," and offer a smaller version. Repeat until the recovery sounds relaxed.

Day 6 — Compress for text

Rewrite five reflections as one-sentence messages you'd actually send. Strip any therapy-sounding words and add a release line where a text might misread.

Day 7 — Use one, then stop

In a real conversation, offer exactly one feeling-plus-need reflection, pause, and stop. Note what signal came back and whether a simpler move would have been better.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I have real evidence for both the feeling and the need?
- Did I phrase it tentatively and keep them the authority on their experience?
- Did I offer one need, not three, and avoid diagnosing?
- Did I stop after one move and pause long enough to calibrate?
- Did I take correction without defending my interpretation?
- Did I switch to action the moment action was what was needed?